

1.1.1. Exposure: Point And Shoot Vs. Manual Control

One of the most confusing as well as most important areas in getting good-quality video are the settings that control focus, shutter speed, and exposure. Manufacturers, in a bid to reduce the confusion, provide “automatic modes” where the camcorder’s internal computer judges the correct settings for any given condition. This, however, is a subjective area, and each camcorder model handles this in a different way. Some are better than others.

Most camcorders these days provide different preset modes that can be activated with a button, slider or dial. These pre-set modes are optimised



(supposedly) for different settings such as Indoors, Outdoors (sunny/cloudy), Sports, Candlelight, etc. Again, some camcorders are better at it than others. You will need to test and compare different models before letting yourself be satisfied with your choice of camcorder.

For the budding film maker and gizmo geek who wants absolute control over his shot, mid-range and higher-end models offer a wide range of manual control over each and every aspect of the exposure. However, one problem with manual control is the proliferation of buttons and menu options. If manual control is your thing, make sure you test out the camcorder at all imaginable settings for ease of use and quick access to the required menu options. Struggling to adjust the settings in the middle of a shot is not a pretty picture!

1.1.2. Handling Comfort

One factor that should be considered independent of need is handling comfort. This may sound like a minor issue, but after even